MODULE - III

ETHICAL THEORIES

CONSEQUENTIALIST THEORIES – HEDONISM- UTILITARIANISM

DEONTOLOGICAL – CATEGORICAL IMPERATIVE

1. To introduce Ethical theories.
2. To introduce Hedonism,Consequentialism,Deontology.
3. To explain Hedonism
4. To explain Utilitarianism
5. To explain Deontology

3.1 Ethical Theory: An Introduction

Ethical theory is a systematic attempt to understand, explain, and justify moral principles that guide human conduct. It deals with fundamental questions such as What is right and wrong?, What makes an action morally good or bad?, and How should human beings live? Ethical theories provide frameworks through which moral issues can be analyzed rationally rather than being guided solely by personal feelings or social customs.

Ethics, derived from the Greek word ethos meaning character or custom, is a branch of philosophy that studies moral values and moral behavior. Ethical theory seeks to establish standards of moral judgment and to justify them through reasoned arguments.

3.1.1 Nature and Purpose of Ethical Theory

The primary purpose of ethical theory is to provide a rational basis for moral decision-making. Human beings constantly face moral dilemmas in personal, social, and professional life. Ethical theories help individuals evaluate actions, intentions, and consequences in an objective manner. They also aim to promote moral consistency, reduce moral conflicts, and contribute to a just and harmonious society.

Ethical theory is not merely abstract speculation; it has practical relevance. It guides laws, public policies, social institutions, and personal conduct. By offering moral principles, ethical theories help individuals act responsibly and consciously.

3.1.2 Major Ethical Theories

Ethical theories are generally classified into different types based on the criteria they use to judge moral actions.Here we take in to account the following ethical theories

1. **Consequentialist Theories**

Consequentialist theories judge the morality of an action based on its outcomes or consequences. The most prominent form of consequentialism is Utilitarianism, advocated by thinkers such as Jeremy Bentham and John Stuart Mill. According to utilitarianism, an action is morally right if it produces the greatest happiness for the greatest number of people. Pleasure and happiness are considered the ultimate moral goals.

2. **Deontological Theories**

Deontological theories emphasize duty, rules, and intentions rather than consequences. Immanuel Kant is the chief exponent of this approach. Kant argued that moral actions are those performed out of a sense of duty and guided by universal moral laws. According to him, actions should be judged by their motives and whether they respect human dignity, not by their results.

3.2 Standard as pleasure

Any mental process may have the quality either of pleasantness or of unpleasantness. But it has always other qualities as well. Pleasantness seems to occur in the mind under various conditions; (a) as a normal quality of certain sensations and perceptions such as the sensation of sweetness and the perception of beautiful objects; (b) as an accompaniment of any activity either bodily or mental, provided that the activity is not imposed on its agent from outside or impeded by fatigue or some other impeding factor; (c) as an accompaniment of the successful completion of any activity; (d) as an accompaniment of the attainment of a desire which is, of course, a special case of the successful completion of an activity, but which is such an important source of pleasantness, that it worth mentioning specially. When a desire attains the end to which it is directed, the desire is satisfied; and this satisfaction is attended by an agreeable feeling of pleasure, enjoyment, or happiness. On the other hand, when the end of a desire is not attained, we have a disagreeable feeling-a feeling of pain, misery, or

unhappiness. Now it seems plausible to say that, since what we aim at is the satisfaction of our desires, the best aim is that which will bring the greatest number of pleasure and the smallest number of pains. The highest universe, in fact, would be that which is constituted by the consideration of our greatest happiness throughout life; or, if consider others as well as ourselves, by the consideration of the greatest happiness of the greatest number. This lead s us to the consideration of Hedonism.

3.3 Hedonism

Hedonism is the general term for those theories that regards happiness or pleasure as the supreme end of life. Hedonism the term derives from the Greek word hēdonē, which means "delight". Hedonism is a school of thought that argues that pleasure is the only intrinsic good. In very simple terms, a hedonist strives to maximize net pleasure and minus pain. These theories have taken many different forms. According to the nature of seeking pleasure hedonism can be divided broadly in to two: Psychological Hedonism and Ethical Hedonism.

(a) **Psychological Hedonism:-** It has been held by some that men always do seek pleasure. i. e. that pleasure in some from is always ultimate object of desire. This theory holds that this is not the way people ought to be; this is the way people actually are—they naturally seek pleasure. Prof. Sidgwick called this position as psychological hedonism, because it simply affirms the seeking of pleasure as a psychological fact.

(b) **Ethical Hedonism:-** whether or not people pursue pleasure, they should or ought to do so. A right action is productive of pleasure; a wrong action is productive of pain. Ethical hedonism is the idea that all people have the right to do everything in their power to achieve the greatest amount of pleasure possible to them.

Most of the earlier ethical hedonists were also psychological hedonists; but this latter view has now been almost universally abandoned. Psychological hedonism is simply a state ment of fact; whereas Ethical hedonism is a theory of value, a theory of the ground upon which one form of action ought to be preferred to others.

Again, ethical hedonism can be divided into two according to their nature of seeking pl easure: some have held that what each man seeks, or ought to seek, is his own pleasure; while others hold that what each seeks or ought to seek, is the pleasure of all human beings, or even all sentient creatures. Prof. Sidgwick has called the former of these views Egoistic Ethical Hedonism; the latter, Universalistic Ethical Hedonism or Utilitarianism.

I. **Egoistic Ethical hedonism:-** Is the theory that we ought, morally speaking, to do whatever makes us happiest – that is whatever provides us with the most net pleasure after pain is subtracted. The most repugnant feature of this theory is that one never has to ascribe any value whatsoever to the consequences for anyone other than oneself. For example, a Hedonistic Egoist who did not feel saddened by theft would be morally required to steal, even from needy orphans.

II. **Universalistic Ethical Hedonism or Utilitarianism:-** Is the theory that the right action is the one that produces the greatest net happiness for all concerned. Hedonistic Utilitarianism is often considered fairer than Hedonistic Egoism because the happiness of everyone involved is taken into account and given equal weight Utilitarianism, then, tend to advocate not stealing from needy orphans because to do so would usually leave the orphan far less happy and the thief only slightly happier. Some more modern writers such as Bentham and Mill- did not clearly distinguish between egoistic and universalistic hedonism and consequently, though in the main supporting the Utilitarianism.

3.4 UTILITARIANISM

The term ‘utilitarianism’, gives emphasis on utility or usefulness rather than on pleasure. Utilitarianism holds that the proper course of action is the one that maximizes the overall "good" of the society. The proponents of the theory are Jeremy Bentham, James Mill and his son John Stuart Mill. Jeremy Bentham and John Stuart Mill defended the ethical theory of utilitarianism. The slogan of the utilitarian school are ' the greatest happiness of the greatest number' .This slogan emphasized the wide distribution of human pleasure as well as its maximization. An action is right as long as it increases well being. Utilitarianism as an ethical theory was systematically developed in the late 18th century.

In purely hedonistic theory, it does not bother whether human pleasure was distributed among many or confined to few until the greatest possible amount of pleasure was achieved. Conjoining hedonism, as a view as to what is good for people, to utilitarianism has the result that all action should be directed toward achieving the greatest total amount of happiness (Hedonic Calculus).

There are some differences in Jeremy Bentham and James Mill school of Hedonism

3.4.1 Bentham- Quantitative Utilitarianism

Bentham considered happiness as the ultimate good and that happiness was pleasure and absence of pain. They defended that maximization of happiness was the correct criterion for moral behaviour although they acknowledged the fact that it is the egoistic and hedonistic nature which drives their motivation.

Bentham's greatest happiness principle states that actions are immoral if they are not the action that appears to maximise the happiness of all the people likely to be affected; only the action that appears to maximise the happiness of all the people likely to be affected is the morally right action.

In the justification of legal reforms also Bentham used his dictum of greatest happiness of the greatest number. Though he could not conclusively argue that his principle was the correct criterion for morally right action, still he considered it was fair and better than existing criterea for evaluating actions actions and legislations.

The hedonistic calculus was applied to real life situations, by using this calculus one could determine what should be done in a particular situation. The amount of pleasure an pain due to different actions can be counted using the hedonistic calculus. The Hedonic Calculus required a methodology for measuring pleasure, which in turn required an understanding of the nature of pleasure and specifically what aspects of pleasure were valuable for us.

Bentham's Hedonic Calculus identifies several aspects of pleasure that contribute to its value, including certainty, propinquity, extent, intensity, and duration. The Hedonic Calculus also makes use of two future-pleasure-or-pain-related aspects of actions – fecundity and purity. Certainty refers to the likelihood that the pleasure or pain will occur. Propinquity refers to how long away (in terms of time) the pleasure or pain is. Fecundity refers to the likelihood of the pleasure or pain leading to more of the same sensation. Purity refers to the likelihood of the pleasure or pain leading to some of the opposite sensation. Extent refers to the number of people the pleasure or pain is likely to affect. Intensity refers to the felt strength of the pleasure or pain. Duration refers to how long the pleasure or pain are felt for. It should be noted that only intensity and duration have intrinsic value for an individual. Certainty, propinquity, fecundity, and purity are all instrumentally valuable for an individual because they affect the likelihood of an individual feeling future pleasure and pain. Extent is not

directly valuable for an individual's well-being because it refers to the likelihood of other people experiencing pleasure or pain.zBy the inclusion of fecundity, and purity in the Hedonic Calculus Bentham modified his hedonist calculus as seven point calculus.

Bentham's modified seven points Hedonistic Calculus:-

1. Intensity: How strong is the pleasure?

2. Duration: How long will the pleasure last?

3. Certainty or uncertainty: How likely or unlikely is it that the pleasure will occur?

4. Propinquity or remoteness: How soon will the pleasure occur?

5. Fecundity: The probability that the action will be followed by sensations of the same kind.

6. Purity: The probability that it will not be followed by sensations of the opposite kind.

7. Extent: How many people will be affected?

Most importantly for Bentham's Hedonic Calculus, the pleasure from different sources is always measured against these criteria in the same way, that is to say that no additional value is afforded to pleasures from particularly moral, clean, or culturally-sophisticated sources. For example, Bentham held that pleasure from the parlour game push-pin was just as valuable for us as pleasure from music and poetry. Since Bentham's theory of Universal Hedonism focuses on the quantity of the pleasure, rather than the source-derived quality of it, it is best described as a type of Quantitative Hedonism.

3.4.2 J.S. Mill- Qualitative Utilitarianism

James Mill's argument that there is a qualitative difference in pleasure is one of the major contribution to utilitarianism. In Bentham's view all forms of happiness as equal, while James Mill argues that intellectual and moral pleasures are superior to physical forms of pleasure. Mill brings in the distinction between happiness and contentment, he considers happiness having higher value than contentment. The statement that "it is better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied; better to be Socrates dissatisfied than a fool satisfied". exposes this view.

His definition of happiness, as pleasure and avoidance of pain, was the highest good.In Mill's view pleasure differed in quality being either higher or lower pleasures. Mill's hedonism differs from Bentham in his understanding of the nature of pleasures.

The lower pleasures being those associated with the body, which we share with other animals, such as quenching thirst or having sex.

Higher pleasures are associated with the mind, which were thought to be unique to humans, such as pleasure from listening to opera, acting virtuously, and philosophizing. According to Mill, person having the experience of the both kind of pleasures realize that higher pleasures are more valuable. He opposed those who refuted this view by saying that those who cannot understand the value of higher pleasures do not have the capacity for such experiences.

By making the distinction between higher and lower pleasures he is not categorizing it by mere degrees, he views both as entirely different in kind.

Since Mill emphasizes his theory of hedonism by basing itself on the quality of pleasure his theory of hedonism is best described as qualitative hedonism.

The following five statements summarize mill's account of utilitarianism

(a)Pleasure is the only thing that is desirable.

(b) The only proof that a thing is desirable is the fact that people do actually desire it.

(c) Each person desires pleasures which is good for that person, so general happiness is good to everybody.

(d) It is as means to pleasure that people like certain objects.

(e) If a person is acquainted with two different kinds of pleasures,the preference for one pleasure results from the superior quality of one pleasure to another.

3.4.2.1 Understanding J.S Mill's Utilitarianism

Utilitarians accept utility, or greatest happiness principle which holds that actions are right in proportion as they tend to promote happiness,wrong as they tend to produce the reverse of happiness. By happiness it means intended pleasure,and the absence of pain.While by unhappiness it means pain and the privation of pleasure.

In order to understand the idea of pain according to this theory much need to be said. According to Mill,the comparision of epicurean life to that of beasts is degrading since the beasts pleasures do not satisfy a human being's conception of happiness.The faculties of human beings are more elevated than animal appetites.When a person is concious of these faculties then he does consider anything as happiness which does not include their gratification. It can be seen that the utilitarian writers have given a superiority to mental over bodily pleasures. The mental pleasures have superiority in that they have greater permanency also the circumstantial advantages they have rather than their intrinsic nature.The principal of utility recognises the fact that some pleasures are more desirable and more valuable than others.

If we try to understand the quantity and quality of pleasures, it can be the case that all who have experienced two kinds of pleasures give preference to one irrespective of any feeling of moral obligation to prefer that.Then preferred one is a more desirable pleasure.We can find that those who are acquainted with lower and higher pleasures there is a marked preference to the manner of existence which employs their higher faculties.It can also be noted that a being of higher faculties requires more to make him happy,is capable probably of more acute suffering and is certainly accessible to it at more points, than one of the inferior type. But these liabilities does not make him to sink in to what he feels as a lower grade of existence.

What makes an individual to think in this way,an explanation most appropriate would be is the sense of dignity, which all human beings possess in one form or another.Though it may not be in the exact proportions of their higher faculties,but it is very essential part for those on whom it is strong. Anything which conflicts with this sense of justice can be taken as other than momentarily an object of desire to them.

A highly-endowed being will always feel that any happiness which he can look for, as the world is constituted, is imperfect.A highly endowed being does not feel envy towards the being who is unconcious of imperfections,former has learned to bear the imperfections.It is because he does not feel good to which imperfections qualify.It is better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied; better to be Socrates dissatisfied than a fool satisfied.And in any case if the fool or the pig is of different opinion it only because they only know their own side of the story.There are instances where many people who are capable of higher pleasures may under

the influence of temptation,postpone them to lower. But here there is compatibility with the full appreciation of the intrinsic superiority of the higher pleasures.

Even individuals who begin with youthful enthusiasm for everything noble it can be seen that as they advance in years they sink in to indolence and selfishness. It can be understood that those who choose the lower might be just because they have become incapable of the higher. The capacity for nobler feelings is in most natures a very tender plant easily killed, not only by hostile influences, but by mere want of sustenance. The influence of the occupations to which their position in life made them thrown in to and the society to which they are thrown in to have made the nobler pleasures disappear in them. There is loss of high aspirations and intellectual taste in men due to the situation in which they are placed, there is no time for indulging in them as a result they addict them to inferior pleasures since these are the only ones to which they have access. If we need to select which pleasure is be given priority, it should be taken up by those who are qualified by knowledge of both in case they differ in their judgement,then the majority among them should be admitted as final.

Since no pleasure or pain is homogenous also pain is always heterogenous with pleasure. The question that remains is whether the particular pleasure is worth purchasing at the cost of particular pain. When, therefore, those feelings and judgment declare the pleasures derived from the higher faculties to be preferable in kind, apart from the question of intensity, to those of which the animal nature, disjoined from the higher faculties, is susceptible, they are entitled on this subject to the same regard.If it may possibly be doubted whether a noble character is always the happier for its nobleness, there can be no doubt that it makes other people happier, and that the world in general is immensely a gainer by it. Utilitarianism, therefore, could only attain its end by the general cultivation of nobleness of character, even if each individual were only benefited by the nobleness of others, and his own, so far as happiness is concerned, were a sheer deduction from the benefit.

As the greatest happiness principle is regarded as the ultimate end,with reference to and for the sake of which all other things are desirable. So it can be seen as an existence attempt as far as possible from pain also as rich as possible in enjoyments,both in quantity and quality;the test of quality, and the rule for measuring it against quantity, being the preference felt by those

who, in their opportunities of experience, to which must be added their habits of self-consciousness and self observation, are best furnished with the means of comparison.

The utilitarian morality does recognize in human beings the power of sacrificing their own greatest good for the good of others. It only refuses to admit that the sacrifice is itself a good. A sacrifice which does not increase, or tend to increase, the sum total of happiness, it

considers as wasted. The only self-renunciation which it applauds, is devotion to the happiness, or to some of the means of happiness, of others; either of mankind collectively, or of individuals within the limits imposed by the collective interests of mankind.

The multiplication of happiness is, according to the utilitarian ethics, the object of virtue: the occasions on which any person (except one in a thousand) has it in his power to do this on an extended scale, in other words, to be a public benefactor, are but exceptional; and on these occasions alone is he called on to consider public utility; in every other case, private utility, the interest or happiness of some few persons, is all he has to attend to

According to Mill,the observation that utilitarianism renders men cold and unsympathising which also means it takes in to account only the dry and hard consideration of the consequences of actions and not taking their moral estimate the qualities from which those actions emanate.. If the assertion means that they do not allow their judgment respecting the rightness or wrongness of an action to be influenced by their opinion of the qualities of the person who does it. This observation cannot be taken as a complaint not against utilitarianism but it can be understood as an argument against having any standard of morality at all. Since no known ethical standard decides an action to be good or bad because it is done by good or a bad man,still less because done by an amiable, a brave, or a benevolent man or the contrary.

It can be seen that utility being seen as an immoral doctrine by giving it the name of expediency. It means which is expedient for some immediate object,some temporary purpose, but which violates a rule whose observance is expedient in a much higher degree.

An example of expedient in this sense we can look in to the case of a minister who sacrifices the interest of the country to keep himself in place. It is an example of an expedient which is opposed to the right. It for attaining some immediate object, some temporary purpose, but which violates a rule whose observance is expedient in a much higher degree. It can be seen that there is a breach of rule in certain cases of temptation greater than the utility that will in its observance. Now the question arises whether utility is the only creed which furnishes us with excuses in wrong doing. It is actually cheating our own conscience. Almost all ethical doctrines recognize the fact that there are conflicting considerations which is believed by sane persons.

Mill states it is not the fault of any creed , but of the complicated nature of human affairs,that rules of conduct cannot be so framed as to require no exceptions. It can be seen that there is no ethical creed which tempers the rigidity of its laws under the moral responsibility of the agent, for accommodation to peculiarities of circumstances; and under every creed, at the opening thus made, self deception and dishonest casuistry get in.

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3.4.2.2 Ultimate Sanction of the principle of utility

When we try to understand a moral standard there is a question which is asked 'what is its sanction?' also what is the source of its obligation.

Moral philosophy has to give answers for these questions.Usually when we refer to morality it is the customary morality which education and opinion has consecrated, it is the only one which presents itself to the mind. If we try to convince the person about the utilitarian principle he may ask why should he should promote the general happiness. If his happiness lies in something else, why should he go for the happiness of everbody.

It can be conceived that the principle of utility has no reason why it might not have all the sanctions which belong to any other system of morals.It can be that those sanctions are either internal or external. It is the hope of favour and fear of displeasure from our fellow creatures or from the ruler of the universe, along with whatever we may have of sympathy or affection for them or of love and awe of Him, inclining us to do His will independently of selfish consequences.

This shows there is no reason for a person to move away from the utilitarian morality. Men do desire happiness even they are imperfect in their own practise.They feel that their happiness is promoted by desiring the happiness of fellow creatures.It also means those who think that

general happiness is the essence should also believe that it is also that which god approves. So the whole force of external reward and punishment,whether physical or moral. The question remains whether it proceeds from God or our fellow men. The capacities of the human nature admit to the disinterested devotion to either,thus leading to the enforcement of utilitarian morality according to the proportion in which that morality is recognized hence appliances of education and general cultivation are bent for the purpose.

From the stand point of internal sanction of duty, if in any case the duty is violated there is a feeling in the mind of a pain which can be more or less intense. In certain circumstances it feels as if the violation of the duty is an impossibility.In a way it leads people to believe that the idea cannot possibly attach itself to any other objects than those which,by a supposed mysterious law, are found in our present experience to excite it. If we want to violate this standard of right then there is a requirement of breaking the mass of feeling. If broken then it will have to be encountered in the form of remorse.

So the ultimate sanction,of all morality which can be taken as a subjective feeling in our own minds. There is nothing embarrasing to take the standard as utility. Answering the question as to what is the standard of this standard. It can be asserted that just like other standards it is the conscientious feelings of mankind. Firstly the persons who possess such feelings it appeals to is a legitimate requirement for this sanction to have binding efficiency. In persons who lack this feelings, on them morality of any kind has no hold but through the external sanctions. It can be understood that these persons are more obedient to the utilitarian principle rather than other moral principles.

It is certainly proved by experience, that those in whom the feeling exist and in whom it is cultivated this acts with great power with which they are capable. It is found that a person who sees in moral obligation a transcendental fact, an objective reality belonging to the province of things in themselves is likely to be more obedient to it than one who believes it to be entirely subjective having its seat in human consciousness only.

Apart from the expectation of actual reward and punishment,it is the belief in God operates only on conduct through,in proportion to the subjective religious feeling. The sanction for it,since it is disinterested, it is always in the mind itself. According to the transcendental moralist this sanction does not exist in the mind unless it is believed to have its root out of the mind. If the person feels that what restrains himself is the conscience and it is only a feeling in his own mind. He thereby draws the conclusion that when feeling ceases the obligation ceases. Also he can disregard it if he feels it inconvenient. The question arises that whether moral obligation getting a seat outside the mind makes us to get rid of it. Most moralists agree to the generality of mind is thereby making silent the urges of our conscience.

If our feeling of duty is innate,the question arises as to what attaches to itself.If there is any principle of morals to which it is intuitively obligatory then it must be regarding the pleasures and pains of others.In such a case intuitive ethics would coincide with utilitarian ethics.The intuitive moralists do believe that a large part of morality turns upon the consideration due to the interests of our fellow creatures. With regard to the internal sanction, if the transcendental origin of moral obligation provides any additional efficacy to it, it means the utilitarian principle has already the benefit of it.

By taking general happiness as the ethical standard it shows the strength of utilitarian morality,it means the social feelings of mankind,the desire to be in unity with our fellow creatures which is already a powerful principle in human nature.It is happy to notice that it grows stronger from the influences of advancing civilisation.A person conceives himself to be member of a body;and this association is riveted more and more, as mankind are further removed from the state of savage independence. Any condition, therefore, which is essential to a state of society, becomes more and more an inseparable part of every person's conception of the state of things which he is born into, and which is the destiny of a human being.We can find that in all states of civilisation every person has equals except in the case of an absolute monarch,so every one is obliged to live on these terms with somebody. Also in every age there is some advance made towards the state in which it will be impossible to live permanently on other terms with any body. So it makes people unable to conceive as possible to them a state of total disregard of other people's interests. It makes people familiar with the fact of co-operating with others,and proposing to themselves a collective,not an individual interest, as the aim of their actions.

As long as people cooperate their ends are identified with those of others;there is temporary feeling that interests of others are their own interests. It means that the all healthy growth of society give to each individual a stronger personal interest in practically consulting the welfare of others. The good of others becomes to him a thing naturally to be attended to, like any of the physical conditions of our existence.

According to Mill, this feeling of unity if it is taught as a religion and the whole force of education of institutions and of opinion directed,as it once was in the case of religion,to make every person grow up from infancy surrounded on all sides both by the profession and by practise of it, Mill thinks that no one who can realise this conception,will feel any misgiving about the sufficiency of the ultimate sanction for the happiness morality.

It has been understood that there is no moral system in which there is no unequivocal cases of conflicting obligations.

3.5 STANDARD AS LAW

There is convenience in dealing with ethical theory if we take the fundamental conceptions of idea of duty,right,law and obligation as the starting point. Usually it is obedience to law of duty that is presented as morality. The ambiguity in the word law has caused a good deal of confusion in the study of ethics.

In order to solve this issue Mackenzie has tried to distinguish different kinds of laws

(1) changeable or unchangeable, (2) violable or inviolable.

Adopting these two principles, we might evidently have four different classes of laws-

(1) Those that can be changed and violated, (2) those that can be changed but cannot be violated, (3) those that can be violated but cannot be changed, (4)those that can neither be changed nor violated.

Mackenzie considers the laws of ethics to belong to the 3rd class, they cannot be changed but may be violated. The different conditions of life may pose the particular rules of moral code to vary. But the board principles remain always the same, and are applicable not only to all kinds of men, but to all rational beings.

These laws never change. This conception of law as unconditional command is agreed to by Immanual Kant.

3.6 DEONTOLOGICAL ETHICS

3.6.1 Meaning and Nature of Deontological Ethics

Deontological ethics holds that certain actions are morally obligatory, permissible, or forbidden irrespective of their outcomes. This theory asserts that moral rules or duties are absolute or binding, and individuals must follow them even if doing so leads to undesirable consequences. Thus, an action such as telling the truth is considered morally right even if it causes harm, because truth-telling is a duty.

3.6.2 Immanuel Kant and Deontological Ethics

The most influential proponent of deontological ethics is Immanuel Kant. Kant argued that morality is grounded in reason and that moral laws must be universal. His ethical theory is based on the concept of the categorical imperative, which commands actions that are morally necessary without reference to any personal desire or consequence.

Kant formulated the categorical imperative in several ways, two of which are particularly significant:

1. **The Principle of Universality** – One should act only according to maxims that can be willed as universal laws.

2. **The Principle of Humanity** – One should treat humanity, whether in oneself or in others, always as an end and never merely as a means.

According to Kant, actions possess moral worth only when they are performed from duty, not from inclination or self-interest.

3.6.3 Key Features of Deontological Ethics

Deontological ethics is characterized by the following features:

- Primacy of duty over consequences
- Moral absolutism, where certain acts are always right or wrong

- Respect for human dignity and rights
- Emphasis on intention rather than outcomes
- Universality of moral laws

3.6.4 Strengths of Deontological Ethics

One of the major strengths of deontological ethics is that it provides a strong foundation for human rights and justice. By insisting that individuals must never be treated merely as means, it upholds the intrinsic worth of every person. It also promotes moral consistency and integrity by encouraging people to act according to principles rather than convenience.

3.6.5 Criticisms of Deontological Ethics

Despite its strengths, deontological ethics faces several criticisms. Critics argue that it is too rigid and fails to consider the complexities of real-life situations. Strict adherence to rules may sometimes lead to morally troubling outcomes, such as refusing to lie even to save an innocent life. Additionally, conflicts between duties can arise, and deontological ethics offers limited guidance on how to resolve such conflicts.

3.6.6 Contemporary Relevance of Deontological Ethics

In contemporary ethical debates, deontological ethics remains highly relevant. It plays a crucial role in discussions about medical ethics, legal rights, professional codes of conduct, and human rights. Principles such as informed consent, confidentiality, and respect for autonomy reflect deontological thinking.

3.7 KANTIAN ETHICS

Immanuel Kant introduced important conception with reference to moral law. He regards conscience as practical reason and imposes moral law upon itself. The moral law is apriori and not empirical. It is known intuitively and is self evident. From the moral law kant

deduces the maxims of morality. It is by agreement or disagreement with the moral law that the wrongness or rightness of the moral law is inferred. It is the purity or the motive behind the act that determines the moral quality rather than by its consequences. The moral principles are not given a philosophical justification by the intuitionists. But Kant provides a philosophical justification for the moral law. It is the internal world of conscience that Kant regards as the moral standards. So instead of teleological ethics Kant advocates jural ethics. Conscience is moral or practical reason.

3.7.1 Categorical imperative

The ultimate moral standard that Kant advocates is practical reason or the internal law of conscience. Moral law is then a categorical imperative. It is not assertion of facts instead rather it is an imperative or a command. A psychological law also is assertorial. All persons act to relieve a feeling of want -it is an assertion of fact. But the moral law is not assertorial, but imperative. It is 'categorical' or unconditional. It is not derived from experience rather it is a apriori;free from empirical facts and in all circumstances it ought to be done. Also it is known in advance of a particular situation. We need to act in a particular way if we are to realize an end but here it is not the case. Usually, laws that are meant to realize an end are of the nature of hypothetical imperatives. In the case of economic laws they are conducive of wealth, they are termed hypothetical imperatives. In the case of categorical imperative, the moral law is imposed by practical reason upon itself. It is an end in itself, we do not obey it for the sake of any other end it demands unconditional obedience, it is not a means to higher end.

It is no absolute unconditional command which admits no questions. What we ought to do we ought to do. It cannot be set aside by any higher law. The Categorical Imperative or the moral law has no reference to any external ends, but simply to the right direction of the will itself. The Categorical Imperative is the universal moral law it applies to all persons. It is common to all mankind.

Postulates of morality

1. The postulate of morality considers freedom of the will as fundamental. It is the necessary condition for fulfillment of morality “Thou oughest; there for thou canst”. Freewill is implied by morality. If the freewill is not free, morality becomes impossible. We are directly conscious of our duty or moral obligation. There is pre-supposition of freedom in acts of moral obligation. We can find reconciliation of freedom and morality in Kant's thought. The self being nominal above causality is free. The self as empirical, i. e, a series of mental state, subject to necessity, determination or causal law. There is no contradiction in this view according to him.

2.Immortality of soul is another postulate of morality. Morality consists in overcoming the perpetual conflict of desire with duty. Desire cannot be eliminated in this finite life. It will require infinite life during which sensibility or desire will be gradually eliminated

3.The existence of God is another postulate of morality. Virtue is considered the supreme good, virtue and happiness together constitute the complete goodness. It can be seen that virtuous are seldom happy, but our moral consciousness demands that they be happy. God being above all being controller of the realm of nature and the realm of spirits will reward the virtuous with happiness in the next world. He will harmonize virtue with happiness and bring about the complete good. Thus, the freedom of the will, immortality of soul, and the existence of God are postulates of morality.

Kant's categorical imperative is a pure form of morality, it does not recognize the importance of matter or content of morality which is supplied by feelings or desire. Kant regards duty as the fundamental concept of ethics which is called 'deontological'. In Teleological view the fundamental concept of ethics end or purpose of life. There is a unique moral motive that Kant stresses upon the sense of duty. There is a motive behind all our actions, motive being either sense of duty or self-interest.

The only morally good motive is the sense of duty. Kant further assumes that if an action is done from inclination or self interest, then it is done in order to satisfy this inclination. Kants vision is bring to forefront the deontological concepts in ethics.

CRITICISMS

1. **Psychological dualism**- Kant's view is based on psychological dualism of reason and sensibility. He sets up an antagonism between reason and sensibility or desire. The mind is an organic unity of both the elements. Sensibility is the matter of moral life, which should be subjected to the reason. Feeling gives the matter to desire; desire gives rise to activity. There is no action without sensibility. The moral life is an active life. Action implies feeling and desire. Thus the moral life implies sensibility as a necessary element in it.

2. **Asceticism-** Kant emphasizes a ascetic view of morality. The dominant note of asceticism is seen in Kant's ethical system. By considering sensibility as irrational and that morality consists in the total extirpation of sensibility, because sensibility has its proper place and function in the nature of the self, and because virtue truly consists in the matter of moral life. They should be regulated by reason which supplies the form or moral law.

3. **Formalism-** It is feeling and desires which form the entire content of morality, and what is left is only its empty form. Kant's ethical doctrine is formalistic in the sense that separates the form from the matter of morality. Reason gives the form or the categorical imperative. But what gives us the matter to which the form is applied? The will willing itself is an absurdity; it leads to sheer formalism; sensibility is the matter to which the form is applied. In other words, it is reason which regulates and transforms sensibility according to the moral law. Jacobi rightly describes the pure will of Kant, devoid of particular content, as "a will that wills nothing

MODEL QUESTIONS

Answer the following

(short answer questions)

1.Define Hedonism

2.Define Utilitarianism

3.Discuss J.S.Mill's Qualitative utilitarianism.

4. Explain Deontological ethics.

5.Examine the role of free will in Kantian philosophy.

6. Examine Formalism inherent in Kant's ethical thought.

7.Explain the concept of categorical imperative

Answer the following

6. Discuss Bentham's Hedonistic Calculus.

7. What is Quantitative Utilitarianism? Elaborate.